

How to build a client avatar for a video business

A client avatar is one buyer described in enough detail that you can write every quote, email and web page to that person. Build it from a real client you'd happily work for again, in 13 steps that run from who they are, through how they decide and who else has a say, to what would turn them into a fan. Build one for each type of client, starting with the clients your audit shows are worth more of.

Why does a pitch about selling more products miss the buyer?

A pitch about selling more products misses the buyer whenever sales aren't that buyer's main trigger. Plenty of production companies open with some version of "a video will help you sell more of your products." For a head of communications in a large organisation, getting a policy across to the internal team, or a safety briefing that brings the accident rate down, may matter far more.

A client avatar makes you choose one buyer and learn what they weigh when they decide, so the pitch answers their trigger. Writing to one person will put some people off, and a few will tell you how to run your marketing. Ignore them. Why a long list of services gets ignored is covered in [the message equation](#).

Which client should the avatar be built on?

Build the avatar on a real client you like working with. Most of your sales come from a small share of your clients (the 80/20 principle), so start with the clients [your twelve-month audit](#) shows are worth more of.

An ideal client is fair, says clearly what they want, understands you're in business to make a profit, pays what you charge, gives you room to decide, and comes back because they trust you. If you don't have one yet, describe the one you want.

Pick one to three types of client and run the 13 steps for each. In an early workshop I put two side by side: the client I wanted to keep, and the client I'd avoid at any cost.

How to build a client avatar: the method, step by step

The 13 steps move from the facts about the buyer, to how they decide, to what you'll say and do. Before you start, run three to five recorded interviews with clients you'd like more of using [the ASK framework](#), so steps 1, 8 and 13 come from their words rather than your guesses.

1. **Wants, needs, desires and aspirations.** From the project, the role and their working life. Write them down in their words from the interviews.
2. **Demographics and psychographics.** Demographics are the dry facts about who is buying: age, family, job title, time in the role, how much of it involves commissioning video, team, earnings. Psychographics are why they buy: personality, lifestyle, attitudes, beliefs, life outside work. Give them a first name, then write both.
3. **Their order of business needs.** Seth Godin's hierarchy of business needs lists six things people weigh when they buy for a business: avoid risk, avoid hassle, gain praise, gain power, have fun, make a profit. Rank the six for this buyer.
4. **The dream scenario.** What does complete success look like? Write the scene and the feelings that come with it, such as pride, hope or joy.
5. **The nightmare scenario.** What does failure look like, and how does it make them look? Write the scene and the feelings, such as regret, blame or worry.
6. **Their emotional triggers when they decide.** Whose money is it, how much video have they bought before, and what are they nervous about?
7. **How aware they are.** Eugene Schwartz's five levels of customer awareness run from unaware, through problem aware, solution aware and product aware (they know you but haven't hired you), to most aware (they ring you with the next project). Steer away from the unaware, who don't yet know they have a problem. Write down where this buyer sits when they first meet you.
8. **Their current problems, and what's causing them.** A complex technical idea to explain, a product launch, internal comms, never having made a video before. Write each problem in their words, with its cause.
9. **The five things that will solve their problems.** This is how you'll describe your help. Write five in their language; my versions are below.

Copy and paste: five lines that answer a buyer's problem

We know your market, and we'll make a film that delivers the business outcome you want.

Where it helps, we'll suggest another way of looking at it, based on work we've done before: "We did a project for [similar client] and I think that concept may work here."

We'll deliver within budget and make it easy for you, even if you've never done this before.

We'll make a film to your brief, not to our own creative needs.

We'll communicate consistently, so you know what to expect at every stage of production.

10. **The three to five things they should hear from you.** Set out the reality of what they're trying to achieve before they commit: what they've asked for may not be the only option, or the right one.
11. **The three to five things they want to hear.** Go back to the ranking from step 3 and answer the top few needs directly, one line each.
12. **Who else has a say.** A boss, a business partner, a spouse in the business. For each: what matters to them, what they want to avoid and to achieve, and what they think your buyer is thinking. (On a live enquiry, ask it with **the qualifying questions**.)
13. **The experience that turns them into a raving fan.** What experience can you give them, during the job and after it, that would turn them into a raving fan? Write down the outcome, and who notices it.

Write the avatar up on one A4 page and give it a first name. Paste the worksheet into a document and fill it in.

Copy and paste: the client avatar worksheet

Avatar first name: []. Type of client: []. Built from (real client or interviews): []

1. Wants, needs, desires and aspirations, in their words: []

2. Demographics: []. Psychographics: []

3. Business needs ranked 1 to 6 (avoid risk, avoid hassle, gain praise, gain power, have fun, make a profit): []

4. Dream scenario, and how it feels: []

5. Nightmare scenario, and how it feels: []

6. Emotional triggers when deciding: []

7. Awareness when they first meet us (unaware, problem, solution, product, most aware): []

8. Current problems, and what's causing each: []

9. Five things that will solve their problems: [1] [2] [3] [4] [5]

10. Three to five things they should hear from us: []

11. Three to five things they want to hear: []

12. Who else has a say: [role]. What matters to them: []. What they want to avoid: []. What they want to achieve: []. What they think our buyer is thinking: []

13. The experience that would turn them into a raving fan: []

The client we'd avoid, in three lines: []

A worked example: two buyers for the same production company

Beth and Bill are illustrations from my avatar workshop, not real clients. Either could hire the same production company, and you wouldn't talk to them the same way.

Step	Beth	Bill
2. Who they are	29, marketing lead at a large healthcare device manufacturer, lives in the London suburbs. Yoga, vegan, lives as green as she can.	62, owns an engineering firm making parts for aircraft and yacht vacuum toilets. His wife is the CFO. Golf every Saturday, likes to spend on quality.
3. Top needs	Gain praise, have fun. Profit sits low.	Avoid risk, avoid hassle, make a profit.
6. Emotional triggers	Spending part of her department's budget on a product launch. Two video campaigns behind her, stretched across several projects, nervous about the spend next to print.	Spending his own money. Can't be fooled by flashy creative, wants a tangible outcome.
7. Awareness	Solution aware: she worked with a production company in her last job and still knows the crew.	Problem aware: his daughter, who works in marketing, keeps telling him to make a video for Facebook.
12. Who else has a say	Her boss, who fears a budget blowout and is testing Beth on a bigger project before promoting her.	His wife, protecting profit ahead of an exit in three years, and his daughter, wary he'll get ripped off.
13. Raving fan	Her boss credits her judgement, the MD praises the campaign, and the team line you up for a chat about more projects.	A lapsed client sees the video on LinkedIn and places an order. He recommends you to his suppliers.

Beth needs the step 10 lines: a clear brief, on time and on budget, an enjoyable process, and a film that earns her praise for the decision. Bill needs the budget, the outcome and a reference: "We did a project for a wheel manufacturing company last year, and I think that film might work well here."

The mistakes that undo it

Three habits stop the avatar from showing up in your marketing.

- **Making the avatar up.** Base it on real people and real interviews, and make it specific.
- **Using one avatar for every buyer.** Beth and Bill have different needs, different fears and different people in their ear.
- **Stopping at the demographics.** A job title tells you who is buying. People decide on emotion and back it up with logic afterwards, so the dream, the nightmare and their state of mind matter as much as the job title.

The rule of thumb for client avatars

One avatar for each type of client, built from a real client, with every message written to that one person. Benchmark: one to three client types, three to five ASK interviews, all 13 steps answered, and the result on one A4 page with a first name at the top.

Hold yourself accountable

Which of these have you taken on or put in place recently?

- You've picked one to three client types from the clients your audit shows are worth more of.
- You've booked or run ASK interviews with clients of your main type.
- Your main avatar is on one page, with a first name and all 13 steps answered.
- Your last proposal to that type of client answered their top needs from step 3.

Your one move this week

What's the one thing you can commit to implementing this week? If you're not sure, start here.

Pick the client you'd most like ten more of. Paste the worksheet into a document and fill in steps 2, 3, 6 and 12 from what you already know, in one sitting. Then ask that client for an ASK conversation to check the rest.

One thing executed every week creates 50 strategic moves a year.

Questions like these come up regularly on our weekly Elite Boardroom calls. If you'd like someone to hold you to account each week, and to learn from a group of peers who run video businesses too, [the Boardroom is for you](#).

Related tools and guides. [Choosing a niche](#), [The message equation](#), [The ASK framework](#), [Qualifying a video lead](#), [The twelve-month audit](#).



The field guides show you how the system works. The Boardroom is where I look at your business with you, give you perspective and judgement on what to do next, and hold you to it every week.

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